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We test the latest storage solutions to hit the streets

Bazaar 64

A roundup of latest products in the market

THX is not a recording technology nor a standard format. An acronym for Tomlinson Holman's eXperiment is a hi-fi sound reproduction standard developed by Lucasfilm in 1983

When shopping for speakers, it's important to consider your needs before you go around meeting them. Some people like the idea of a 5.1 speaker system because they feel that if there are actually five speakers, the setup surely must sound better than just two speakers. A few of the more knowledgeable folk may actually figure out that they need a 5.1 speaker system, simply because they watch a lot of movies. For those of our readers who do not know: a 5.1 speaker system does not just have five speakers, but offers up to six channels of sound. These six channels are not used for music alone (which just uses two channels and hence the name stereo), but for movies that have positional surround sound built into them. Suppose you're listening to music on a 5.1 speaker system. Only the two front channels will actually be in use along with the woofer unit — the other three speakers will simply not be used, since music is a two-channel source. Movies are a different story. If there is a scene where the sound source is behind the listener, only the rear speakers play this sound. Similarly, for any sound emanating from the sides, only the corresponding speaker(s) play that sound. This gives the impression of being present in the movie and this sort of positional sound is used by all the movies these days. In fact, if movies are all you're interested in then a 5.1 speaker set is the only way to go. However, cable clutter is always a problem with multi-channel speakers — the more the speakers, the greater the clutter since the number of wires also goes up proportionately. For music, a 5.1-channel setup is largely a waste since most of the time only two speakers will ever be used. For those looking at a solution predominantly for music, a stereo system is what you should look at.

A stereo system can either be a 2.0 system consisting of two satellite speakers

without a woofer for low frequencies, or it could be a 2.1 setup consisting of a woofer unit and two satellite speakers. Other sound setups such as 4.1, 6.1 and 7.1 units do exist, but these are rare to come by these days.

2.0 SPEAKERS Who needs bass?

2.0 speakers are somewhat of a rarity in our markets and the reason for this is the strong emphasis towards bass. 90 per cent of people buying a set of computer speakers look at the bass effect and if all the woofer unit does is belt out loose, boomy and unfocussed bass they like it. A 2.0 speaker basically consists of a speaker system with a left and right channel speaker and no dedicated unit for the lower frequencies. Do not mistake all 2.0 speakers for having weak bass though. This is because some satellite speakers have powerful low frequency units built into them. Although not as powerful as a dedicated woofer or subwoofer, these do pack quite a mean wallop that will satisfy most. However, the regular 2.0 desktop speaker is largely a wimp when it comes to producing tight, powerful bass. This is because they mostly consist of a three to four inch mid-range driver and a smaller unit for

the higher frequencies, but lack a larger driver for the lower frequencies. As most audio enthusiasts will agree — trying to get proper bass on anything less than a 6.5-inch driver is largely a wasted cause irrespective of how finely the driver is tweaked.

Features:

We tested four 2.0-speakers, one each from Altec Lansing, Audio Engine, Artis and Zebronic. The Zebronic ZEB-T9000 was the best looking of the 2.0 speakers and was in fact one of the most appealing speakers from among all the categories in test. It's got a wooden finish and the grain of the wood is nice to look at. Although we would have

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Zebronic ZEB-T 9000

How We Tested

We used a Pentium D 940 (3.0 GHz) CPU, ECS 945P motherboard, MSI GeForce 7300 GS graphics card, 2 GB of Corsair memory and a 250-GB Seagate hard drive. Our soundcard of choice was the ASUS Xonar HDAV 1.3 Deluxe.

We divided the speakers into three rather obvious categories — 2.0, 2.1 and 5.1 speaker systems. First we checked for connectivity — the presence of digital connects i.e. optical or coaxial connectivity. We also logged the presence of volume, bass, treble and other controls. The presence of an external decoder, remote control unit and FM Radio Tuner was also logged. Additionally, we rated the build quality of the knobs, dials and buttons and the stands provided with the satellites. The overall build quality of the product was also graded on a scale of one to ten.

For our performance tests we rated these speakers on a scale of one to ten under both movies and music. For movies, we used select HD clips of *The Transformers* and *Star Wars Episode 3 - Revenge of the Sith*. Both these movies have a lot of action scenes that test the bass and surround capabilities of the speakers to their utmost. The *Revenge Of The Sith* also has a very intense lightsaber duel, which comes with a lot of bass effects — the sound of lightsabers slashing through thin air is very distinctive. *The Transformers* also has a number of very complex audio passages that test the ability to produce a cinematic effect to the sound. The music used is listed in the accompanying table.

<i>Everybody Hurts</i> (The Corrs)	A great track to test the reproduction of female vocals. Andrea Corr works her vocal magic here and we checked for clarity, tonal accuracy and instrument detail
<i>Tears In Heaven</i> (Eric Clapton)	A very good test of guitar and male vocals for slower music, perhaps one of the best. We look for clarity, accuracy, and texture of the vocals and mid-range. Also the tonal accuracy and weight and impact of each guitar pluck
<i>November Rain</i> (Guns N' Roses)	A rock classic. This song has some complex guitar and instrument passages as well as some great vocals from Axel Rose whose growl-cum-scream sounds like nothing else
<i>Money</i> (Pink Floyd)	Pink Floyd remains one of the best tests for sound-staging and instrument separation as well as testing minute details. <i>Money</i> tests sound separation, panning and overall soundstaging
<i>Selkies The Endless Obsession</i> (Between The Buried And Me)	A complex guitar and drums instrumental track featuring lots of instruments at once. Here, separation and accurate rendition of the sound produced by each instrument along with its respective sound bias becomes important